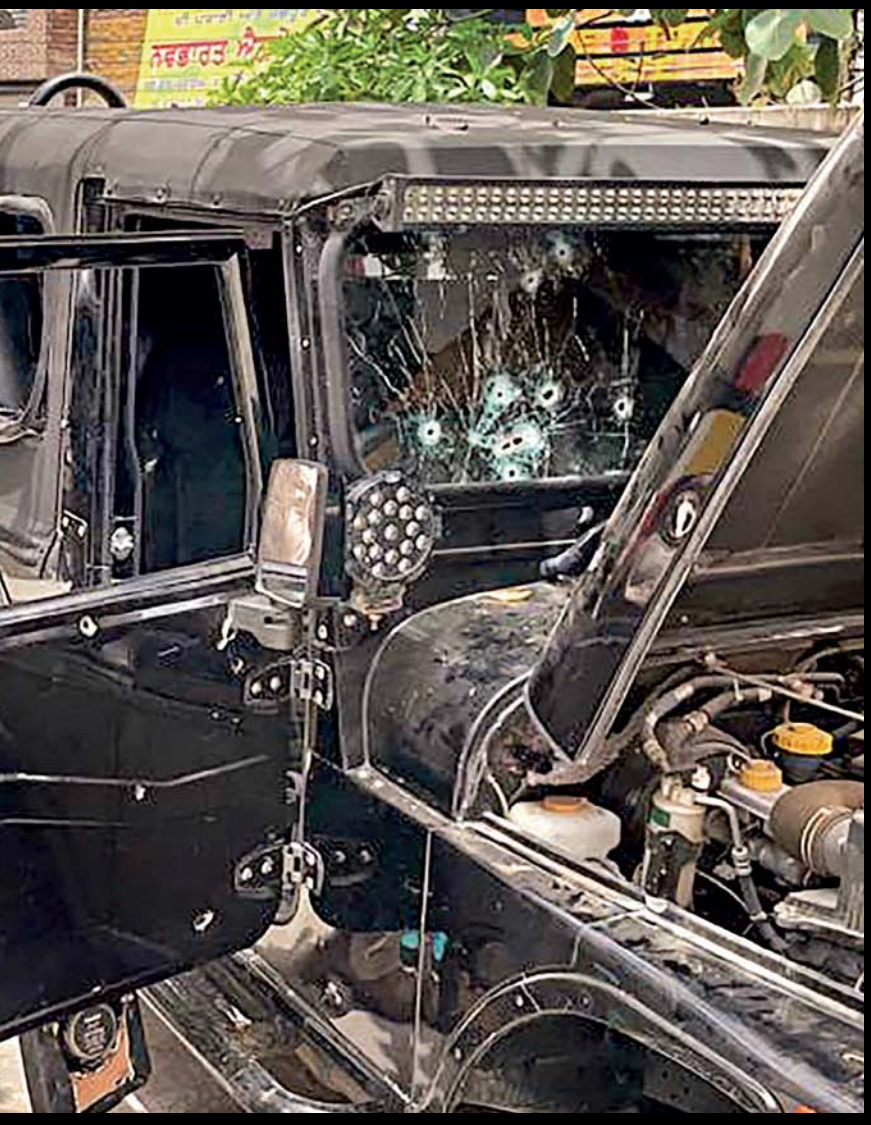






GO OUT WITH A BANG Police scrutinise the bullet-riddled Mahindra Thar in which Moosewala (top right) was killed in rural Punjab on May 29

cast a halo of swashbuckling derring-do around gun culture. Among his chart-toppers are songs with titles like 'Mafia Style', 'Homicide' and 'Warning Shot'. Now, his killing has prised open a whole world the rest of India may not have heard of, although it has pug-marks across the globe—in Canada, the UK and other hotspots warmed by the presence of Punjabi NRIs. A trans-national gangland ecosystem with ties to a bewildering cocktail of interests.

Minutes after TV channels started flashing the news of Moosewala's grue-some end, the screenshot of a Facebook post by Canada-based Satwinderjit Singh alias Goldy Brar started circulat-ing on the WhatsApp boxes of select journalists. Goldy was plainly claiming responsibility for the rapper's murder. His post called it an act of revenge for

THE GANGS HAVE A HAND IN THE MUSIC SCENE, IN DRUGS AND ARMS TRAFFICKING, AND OFFER A FREELANCE ARMY FOR KHALISTANI GROUPS

last year's murder of youth Akali Dal leader Vikramjit Middukhera—who was considered a patron of Goldy and his gang leader, Lawrence Bishnoi. The following day, another post appeared on Facebook, this time apparently from Gaurav 'Lucky' Patiyal, an Armenia-based Punjabi gangster. He vowed to avenge Moosewala's murder, for which he squarely blamed another popular Punjabi singer, Mankirat Aulakh. The singer immediately went live on social media to clarify he had no role in the killing. But that, and subsequent expressions of fraternal feelings towards Moosewala—or Shubhdeep Sidhu, to take his real name—have not sufficed. Aulakh says he's getting regular threats from gangs in Punjab and Haryana.

In many ways, Goldy Brar's FB post is typical of how Punjab's gangs operate; they commit a crime and then brag about it on social media too. In the past decade, this unusual synergy has seen Punjab-based gangs grow bigger in terms of their reach as well as numbers. Just this April, state DGP V.K. Bhawra said Punjab's A, B and C category gangsters numbered 545 a few years back, and 515 had been neutralised—via